

Modal Perfects

CEFR B2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

A modal perfect (modal + have + past participle) talks about the past. The main ones are:

- 1** Must have — a confident guess (She must have overslept).
- 2** Can't / couldn't have — impossible (He can't have known).
- 3** Might / may / could have — a possible guess (They might have left).
- 4** Should have — regret or criticism (You should have told me).

Always write 'have', never 'of': 'should have gone', not 'should of gone'. The verb after 'have' is a past participle (gone, seen, done).

At a glance

Meaning	Form	Example
Confident guess (positive)	must have + participle	She must have left.
Impossible (negative guess)	can't / couldn't have + participle	He can't have finished.
Possible guess	might / may / could have + participle	They might have missed it.
Regret / criticism	should have + participle	You should have called.

Learning objectives

- Can form modal perfects with modal + have + past participle (CEFR B2).
- Can choose between must have, can't have, might have and should have by meaning.
- Can avoid the 'should of' spelling error.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Modal Perfects · CEFR B2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. The streets are wet. It ____ rained last night.

- | | |
|--------------|-----------------|
| A. must have | B. must |
| C. must of | D. must to have |

2. She's not answering. She ____ gone to bed already.

- | | |
|---------------|-------------|
| A. might have | B. might |
| C. might of | D. might to |

3. You ____ told me it was your birthday! I'd have got a cake.

- | | |
|----------------|--------------|
| A. should have | B. should |
| C. should of | D. must have |

4. He ____ finished the marathon — it started only ten minutes ago!

- | | |
|----------------|---------------|
| A. must have | B. can't have |
| C. should have | D. might have |

5. Correct this: 'I could of helped you.'

- | | |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------|
| A. I could have helped you. | B. I could helped you. |
| C. I could of helped you. | D. I could to have helped you. |

6. The lights are off and the car's gone. They ____ left.

- | | |
|----------------|-------------------|
| A. must have | B. can't have |
| C. should have | D. might not have |

7. Choose the correct participle: 'She must have ____ the message.'

- | | |
|--------|-----------|
| A. saw | B. seen |
| C. see | D. seeing |

8. I feel awful. I ____ eaten that leftover fish.

- | | |
|-------------------|------------------|
| A. shouldn't have | B. shouldn't |
| C. mustn't have | D. couldn't have |

9. Why didn't he reply? He ____ seen the email.

- | | |
|-----------------|---------------|
| A. may not have | B. may not |
| C. mayn't have | D. may not of |

10. Which sentence expresses REGRET about the past?

- | | |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| A. She must have missed the bus. | B. He can't have known. |
| C. I should have studied medicine. | D. They might have arrived. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. must have** — A confident past guess takes 'must have + participle': 'It must have rained'.
2. **A. might have** — A possible past guess takes 'might have + participle': 'She might have gone to bed'.
3. **A. should have** — Regret/criticism takes 'should have + participle': 'You should have told me'.
4. **B. can't have** — Impossibility takes 'can't have + participle': 'He can't have finished'.
5. **A. I could have helped you.** — The word is 'have', not 'of': 'I could have helped you'.
6. **A. must have** — The evidence makes you sure: 'They must have left'.
7. **B. seen** — After 'have' use the past participle: 'must have seen'.
8. **A. shouldn't have** — Regret takes 'shouldn't have + participle': 'I shouldn't have eaten that fish'.
9. **A. may not have** — A negative past possibility takes 'may not have + participle': 'He may not have seen it'.
10. **C. I should have studied medicine.** — 'I should have studied medicine' expresses regret about the past.